

Episode 51: Special Edition – One More Time Only! *Hakaba Kitaro* Colour Design Notes–Style Episode Commentary!

Yesterday there was an interview for the booklet to be included in *Hakaba Kitaro* DVD volume 4. Following director Chioka and animation supervisor Yamamuro, it was a group interview with art director Kurahashi, CG director Morita, and myself. The interviewer was Haraguchi-san from "List Production Committee." Oh! I met him for the first time.

The interview started pleasantly, but man, I was already starting to forget various things (bitter laugh). This wasn't just me—both Kurahashi-san and Morita-san were the same. I heard that director Chioka and Yamamuro-san were the same too. My goodness (bitter laugh). We tend to forget previous works so they don't interfere with the next ones, so we have that tendency.

But as we talked under Haraguchi-san's guidance, the three of us gradually remembered various things, and by the end of the roughly 2-hour interview, our memories of that time had become quite clear (laugh).

On the same day, we also finished checking the temporary assembly of the DVD volume 3 and 4 jacket images. Is this farewell to *Hakaba Kitaro*? So this interview felt like a good closure for us too.

Well then.

After Haraguchi-san's interview, I felt like I hadn't talked enough (laugh), and at the same time, I thought it might be good to write down somewhere all the various things that I'm forgetting. So suddenly, this time is a colour design-style episode commentary for *Hakaba Kitaro*.

Episode 1: Kitaro's Birth – Storyboard/Chioka Hirotochi, Direction/Hatano Kohei, Colour Direction/Tsujita

I also handled colour direction for episode 1. For series works where I'm entrusted with design, I ask to handle episode 1 colour direction myself unless there are production issues. That's because there are many things you can't understand without doing colour direction yourself. Especially for newly starting works. Beyond what I anticipated at the design stage, various problems and points of attention emerge.

So, episode 1. What was most frustrating was the opening night scene with Mizuki in pyjamas. The colours just wouldn't come out (bitter laugh). That scene was planned to go with blue-toned night colours and I designed and directed colours accordingly, but when photographed, the blue tones were beautifully suppressed and it became almost grey monotone. I had the photography team reshoot it two or three times, but it still didn't work. "So you're that kind of troublemaker, this filter!" I cursed the mysterious characteristics of the "Hakaba filter" (bitter laugh).

Episode 2: Yasha vs. Dracula IV – Storyboard & Direction/Kakudo Hiroyuki, Colour Direction/Akimoto Yuki

This episode's production was quite last-minute, a difficult birth spanning the New Year. Dark clouds began gathering with talk that photography was incredibly difficult and taking too much time—this was episode 2. With the bonus that Yasha was all CG processing (bitter laugh). But the finished result was beautifully balanced.

For Yasha's colours, I had them output one CG model as Photoshop data, I coloured it, and had the director and episode director check it.

For *Hakaba Kitaro*, we created a "simple conversion filter" for colour direction from the photography filters & textures (let's call it the "Hakaba filter"), and advanced colour direction while placing this on cels. This simple filter couldn't be used with old

Photoshop versions. So we hurriedly had colour director Akimoto-san's machine updated with the latest version. I heard they also got a new machine while they were at it. Thanks to *Hakaba Kitaro* (laugh).

Episode 3: Vampire Tree – Storyboard & Direction/Ueda Hidehito, Colour Direction/Kojima Akihiro

For *Hakaba Kitaro*, we asked production company A-LINE to handle gross production for episodes 3 and 9. So episode 3 actually had very proper scheduling. However, previous episode photography was incredibly delayed, so we had them wait quite a bit.

In episodes 1 and 2, I had assembled detailed special colouring according to scene brightness, but while designing episode 3, I realised "Ah, *Hakaba Kitaro* actually shouldn't do too much detail," and suddenly increased scenes with so-called "normal" colour direction. I did the same for subsequent episodes basically.

Instead, for scenes like Shigei's "transformation" in the theatres, I told the colour director "Up to you!" (laugh). But Kojima-san perfectly hit the mark and built it up. Thank you!

Episode 4: Neko – Storyboard & Direction/Nakamura Tetsuji, Colour Direction/Sakuma Yoshiko

When you say "cats," it's colour director Sakuma-san (laugh). At Toei, production tends to dislike having multiple colour directors rotating through one series. But I pushed and had Sakuma-san participate. This created a three-team system: Akimoto = Sakuma = gross production episodes. Otherwise, one person handling such heavy weekly work would be impossible.

So, episode 4. It's all about "Meroron" (laugh). During production, that melody endlessly repeated in my head (laugh). No, I didn't dislike it at all. I quite liked it.

For Neko's skirt and stage costume, we had them shoot by overlaying the red parts again over the "Hakaba filter." Otherwise that impressive red wouldn't come out. Similar processing was done for Dracula's eyes in episode 2.

This episode had many theatres interiors and crowds, plus special colouring. Sakuma-san helped us with everything.

The note about background characters in *Hakaba Kitaro* was "brown hair is NG." For period accuracy in the 1950s, ordinary people wouldn't have brown hair (laugh). Brown hair would only look like "foreigners," so we avoided that. Naturally, green or purple hair was also NG (laugh).

For the latter half bridge scene, I actually made a mistake with Neko's sunset colour balance at the design stage. The broadcast version stayed subtle, but we've corrected it for the DVD.

Episode 5: False Kitaro – Storyboard/Chioka Hirotoshi, Direction/Hatano Kohei, Colour Direction/Akimoto Yuki

Neko who went to hell has white-outlined visuals in the original too, but wanting to make it slightly more alien—or having an atmosphere of going "over there"—I tried softening shadow boundary lines with Paintman colouring software brush processing. This was quite good, I think—shameless self-praise (laugh).

Incidentally, when False Kitaro meets Neko, there's a close-up of Neko's face where False Kitaro reflects in her eyes after blinking—the moment he reflects, Neko suddenly changes to bluish colouring. Actually, that was a photography mistake where only that spot doesn't have the "Hakaba filter" on the cel. But the accident created such a good effect that it became "OK!" So that white Neko was actually that blue Neko during colouring.

This episode was the end of the "Neko arc" and the first half of *Hakaba Kitaro*. A turning point where newborn Kitaro sheds his skin through various experiences. After this, Kitaro becomes greedy about "living" and increasingly adapts to the human world.

When I finished up to here, there was a strange sense of relief like "Ah, it's fine now." The worldview of *Hakaba Kitaro* that we'd advanced by trial and error somehow fit well with me.

Episode 6: Water God – Storyboard & Direction/Ishiguro Iku, Colour Direction/Makabe Genta

Episode 6 was produced by Studio Doga Kobo. From this episode, it gradually becomes more omnibus-like. Kitaro with a somewhat "vacant" feeling. Visually, the screen filter was changed to white-based, changing the atmosphere from episodes 1-5.

However, was the colour direction data changed? Not at all—we used the same data from episode 1. If it looks very bright, that might be episode 6's directorial mood.

The Water God sphere appearing over Ginza (?) had its colour atmosphere provided by me, with the rest being photography director Iribe-san's technique. Tanks, fighter planes, great floods—*Hakaba Kitaro*'s biggest spectacle episode. Work-wise, it was also a difficult episode. Anyway, it was an episode with tonnes of characters without character settings, and I'm endlessly grateful to the colour director who handled all those background characters well.

Episode 7: Werewolf and Ghost Train – Storyboard & Direction/Shibata Hiroki, Colour Direction/Sakuma Yoshiko

The famous episode "Ghost Train." I was mostly hands-off with this one too (laugh). I left it to Sakuma-san (laugh).

For the ghost train interior, since many cuts were animation, I created colours first and had the art staff match them.

But what was still difficult was reflection-type colour direction. The flame reflection in the scene burning the Water God couldn't create good colours, clashing with the "Hakaba filter." That was a bit disappointing (bitter laugh). Like the sunset colours in episode 5, trying to shift colours toward orange didn't reflect well—that was one characteristic of the "Hakaba filter."

Episode 8: Strange Number One Match – Storyboard & Direction/Kakudo Hiroyuki, Colour Direction/Akimoto Yuki

By this point, except for rough settings I provide, it's mostly "Please handle it, colour directors!" (laugh). The "ha-hi-fu-he-ho" ghosts were all thought up by the colour directors.

The fireball reflection at the opening went well—more shameless self-praise (laugh). For the similar scene in episode 7, since it was outdoors, I didn't add colours particularly for reflection parts, but here being an indoor narrow space, I tried shifting firmly toward blue-white-green.

The white colouring of Murata and Kanemaru in the pitch-black world with the "Guide" uses the same colour construction as episode 5's white Neko. That "Guide" colour came from director Chioka and Yamamuro-san's words "something raw-like" (laugh). Still, the "Guide"—both design and movement are supreme! (laugh).

Episode 9: Johnny in the Fog – Storyboard & Direction/Ueda Hidehito, Colour Direction/Kojima Akihiro

The curry scene with the Prime Minister. Due to the "Hakaba filter," apparently delicious colours wouldn't come out easily, and the colour director worried considerably. Finally, they had it shot with colours overlaid again during photography.

The dissolved Kitaro processing is basically the same as the body fluid processing when Kitaro's father (bandaged man) died in episode 1. Initially, I created colours thinking of Kitaro's skeleton as whitish normal bones, but from director Chioka's request "Shouldn't it have an atmosphere of something not human?" I tried applying rainbow gradation brush to the entire skeleton, and "That's a good feeling." With the same thinking, the "Strange Olympics" ticket in the final episode also has rainbow gradation applied.

This episode also had many night scenes. In *Hakaba Kitaro*, we got through almost all episodes with just variations like outdoor night colours → night colour 1, indoor night colours without light sources → night colour 2. For episode 9 too, meetings were just like "This scene is 'night 1'" and beyond that, I mostly left everything to the colour directors (laugh).

Episode 10: Brigadoon – Storyboard/Sato Jun'ichi, Direction/Hatano Kohei, Colour Direction/Sakuma Yoshiko

The episode that recorded high ratings (laugh).

Initially, I was thinking of desaturating character colours too for the daydream-like space inside Brigadoon, but when I actually placed them on backgrounds, "Ah, normal is fine!" So in this episode, we only changed colours for the temple scene near the end.

The various monsters also had character designer Yamamuro-san and animation supervisor Hakamada-san carefully create character settings for almost everything, allowing proper decisions, which was very helpful. So actually, while the volume was large, it was relatively easy colour direction-wise.

Episode 11: Foolish Man – Storyboard & Direction/Chioka Hirotoshi, Colour Direction/Akimoto Yuki

Actually, I initially planned to do colour direction for this final episode myself. But I thought it might work better to ask Akimoto-san, who had handled several episodes already. Absolutely correct (laugh). Really, interesting screens were created.

In the first half, the surreal screens of tuna, beefsteak, and Chinese food that Rakuyou Roujin devours are Akimoto-san's masterpieces (laugh). Beyond that, I left many detailed things to her.

The "Strange Olympics" "walking giant creatures," "island-like creatures," and "bird that walks one step per thousand years" were submitted with dummy colouring, and I created them while bouncing ideas with the director. Yes, those were all animation + colouring.

Beyond that, I was mostly just watching rushes (laugh). That was the feeling.

This is about it for episode commentary and notes.

Being a short decisive battle escape-type series of just 11 episodes, it became one of the few works where I could give full effort comprehensively. I don't think there will be many works like this, before or after. Being able to participate in such a work was very fortunate, and we achieved good results too—it was great.

And with that, *Hakaba Kitaro* ends (laugh).

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